

## Meze Around the World

Meze are found throughout the Middle East and Mediterranean, albeit under different names or forms. The fashion is believed to have spread from the Sultan's court in Istanbul at the height of the Ottoman empire.

### ISTANBUL

#### Sofyalı 9 inexpensive

**Sofyalı Sokak 9, Tünel; +90 212 245 0362**

In an area famous for its *meyhanes* (taverns), this is one of Istanbul's best, serving superb meze and traditional Anatolian cooking in attractive surroundings and a warm, vibrant, and buzzing atmosphere. Try the specialty, *arnavut ciğeri* (fried lamb liver).

#### Asitane expensive

**Kariye Camii Sokak 6, Edirnekapi; www.asitanerestaurant.com**

Just south of the Chora Church, upmarket Asitane has established a specialty in and a reputation for fine Ottoman cuisine. Its dedicated chefs source original recipes from the kitchens of the old Ottoman palaces and employ original methods of preparation and cooking for all their dishes, including their sumptuous meze.

#### Mikla expensive

**Marmara Pera Hotel, Meşrutiyet Caddesi 15, Tepebaşı; www.miklarestaurant.com**

Considered the city's top table, Mikla is overseen by local "celebrity chef" Mehmet Gürs, who creates stunning modern Mediterranean dishes with Turkish ingredients, cooking methods, and flavors. Spectacular views, impeccable service, and sumptuous decor complement the food.

### SYRIA

Syrian cuisine is one of the oldest, richest, and most sophisticated in the world, and the range of meze found in its restaurants reflects this, combining a wide range of raw ingredients with centuries-old culinary know-how.

#### Bab Al-Hara inexpensive

**Sharia Al-Qaimariyya, Damascus; +963 11 541 8644**

Set deep in the old city close to the Umayyad Mosque, Al-Hara boasts a fervent local following for

its fresh, flavorful, and authentic cooking, at excellent prices, served in an old courtyard house. The meze and grills are a particular specialty.

#### Bazaar Al-Charq moderate

**Between Sharia Al-Mutanabi and Sharia Hammam Al-Tat, Aleppo; +963 21 224 9120**

The cellar-like Charq is cozy, atmospheric, and welcoming. The kitchen offers an impressive variety of Damascene and Aleppine specialties, including a wide range of meze; the heavenly, smoky baba ghanoush (eggplant purée) is a must-try. There's usually live traditional music in the evening.

#### Al-Khawali expensive

**Maazanet al-Shahim, Damascus; +963 11 222 5808**

Considered one of Syria's best restaurants and counting its president among its customers, Al-Khawali is a great choice for sampling meze Syrian-style. Set in a restored Damascene courtyard house dating to 1368, it combines beautiful surroundings with first-class cooking and service.

#### Sissi House expensive

**Just off Saahat Al-Hattab, Jdeideh, Aleppo; www.sissihouse.com**

Considered a cut above in decor, ambience, and cooking, Sissi House attracts a well-heeled and glamorous local following. It specializes in Aleppine cuisine, beautifully prepared, cooked, and served, including a selection of over 50 meze. Classical Arabic music is often played live.

### LEBANON

For many people, Lebanese cuisine forms their main experience of meze, aided undoubtedly by the large Lebanese communities and their eateries found in many Western cities. In Lebanon itself, eating out is an important part of social interaction.

#### Abdel Wahab moderate

**Rue Abdel Wahab El-Inglizi, Achrafiye, Beirut; +961 1 200 552**

With tables spread around the pretty garden and high-ceilinged rooms of an old Ottoman villa, the Abdel Wahab is an atmospheric and romantic place for dinner *à deux*. The lavish buffets are famous and include a wide range of meze, among them several varieties of heavenly hummus.

